

Cable

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LINE3: O 171208Z JAN 95
LINE4: FM AMEMBASSY BELGRADE
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DTG: 171208Z JAN 95
ORIG: AMEMBASSY BELGRADE
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INFO: RUCNDT/USMISSION USUN NEW YORK PRIORITY 1300
RUEHOL/AMEMBASSY BONN PRIORITY 3209
RUEHVB/AMEMBASSY ZAGREB PRIORITY 1657
RUEHFR/AMEMBASSY PARIS PRIORITY 9764
RUEHMO/AMEMBASSY MOSCOW PRIORITY 0772
RUEHLO/AMEMBASSY LONDON PRIORITY 0024
RUEHVI/AMEMBASSY VIENNA PRIORITY 8563
RUEHSQ/USLO SKOPJE PRIORITY 0793
SUBJ: JANUARY 16 MEETING WITH MILOSEVIC

TEXT:
~~CONFIDENTIAL~~ BELGRADE 000169

EXDIS

VIENNA FOR BOSNIA

E.O. 12356: DECL:OADR
TAGS: PREL, SR, HR
SUBJECT: JANUARY 16 MEETING WITH MILOSEVIC

REFTEL: SECSTATE 11303

1. ~~CONFIDENTIAL~~ - ENTIRE TEXT.

2. SUMMARY: I MET WITH MILOSEVIC FOR ABOUT 45 MINUTES ON MONDAY, JANUARY 16, TO DELIVER THE REFTEL DEMARCHE. WHILE ADMITTING THAT TUDJMAN'S DECISION WAS WORRISOME, MILOSEVIC DID NOT CONSIDER IT IRREVOCABLE. HE SAID THAT TUDJMAN HAD DISPATCHED CROATIAN NEGOTIATOR SARINIC TO BELGRADE LAST FRIDAY TO EXPLAIN THE DECISION. SARINIC STRESSED THAT TUDJMAN DID NOT WANT A MILITARY CONFRONTATION WITH KNIN AND WAS RESPONDING TO DOMESTIC PRESSURE. MILOSEVIC EXPRESSED THE VIEW THAT TUDJMAN WOULD "RECONSIDER" THE UNPROFOR DECISION IF IN COMING MONTHS THE ECONOMIC AGREEMENT WAS SUCCESSFULLY

IMPLEMENTED. TO ASSIST SUCH AN OUTCOME, MILOSEVIC ADVISED:

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-- PUTTING EMPHASIS ON RAPID PROGRESS IN
CONFIDENCE-BUILDING AND THE ECONOMIC AGREEMENT;

-- MOVING CAUTIOUSLY ON TABLING OF THE 2-4 PLAN,
WHICH MIGHT LEAD TO POSTURING BY BOTH SIDES AND
JEOPARDIZE THE IMPROVED ATMOSPHERE FROM THE
ECONOMIC AGREEMENT; AND

-- "HELPING" TUDJMAN TO COPE WITH HIS DOMESTIC
OPPOSITION BY PUTTING STRONG, PUBLIC PRESSURE ON
HIM TO REVERSE THE UNPROFOR DECISION.

3. ON BOSNIA, MILOSEVIC VOICED DISAPPOINTMENT THAT
THE LATEST CONTACT GROUP EFFORTS HAD NOT PRODUCED
MORE RESULTS, THOUGH HE REMAINED OPTIMISTIC THAT
NEITHER SERBS NOR MUSLIMS WOULD ALLOW THE
NEGOTIATING OPPORTUNITY OF THE NEXT FOUR MONTHS TO
BE LOST. HE SOUGHT, AS ON PREVIOUS OCCASIONS, TO
CONVEY AN UPBEAT, CONFIDENT STANCE AND NEVER ONCE
MENTIONED UNSC 970, DESPITE REPORTS THAT HE HAD
BEEN VERY UPSET BY IT LAST WEEK. END SUMMARY.

4. AFTER READING THE NON-PAPER WITH REFTEL
DEMARCHE, MILOSEVIC SAID THAT HE APPRECIATED THE
MESSAGE AND SHARED U.S. CONCERN. HE HAD DISCUSSED
THE MATTER WITH CROATIAN NEGOTIATOR SARINIC, WHOM
TUDJMAN HAD DISPATCHED TO BELGRADE LAST FRIDAY.
SARINIC HAD EMPHASIZED THAT TUDJMAN WAS RESPONDING
TO STRONG DOMESTIC PRESSURE AND DID NOT WANT A
MILITARY CONFRONTATION WITH KNIN. HENCE ALMOST SIX
MONTHS HAD BEEN BUILT INTO THE DECISION TO ALLOW
NEW FACTORS TO COME INTO PLAY. MILOSEVIC SAID IT
WAS HIS IMPRESSION THAT TUDJMAN WOULD "RECONSIDER"
THE UNPROFOR DECISION IF IMPLEMENTATION OF THE
ECONOMIC AGREEMENT MADE SUFFICIENT PROGRESS. THIS
AGREEMENT WAS KEY TO DECREASING TENSIONS AND GIVING
BOTH SIDES AN INTEREST IN PEACE. IT WAS THE ONE
AREA IN WHICH RAPID MOVEMENT WAS POSSIBLE IN COMING
MONTHS.

5. MILOSEVIC SAID HE HAD TAKEN ADVANTAGE OF
SARINIC'S PRESENCE TO CALL DOWN MIKELIC AND WORK ON
FURTHER STEPS. THE TWO SIDES WERE NOW VERY CLOSE
ON AN OIL AGREEMENT, WITH ONLY THE NAME OF THE
COMPANY AND THE STATUS OF SEVERAL STATIONS IN
DISPUTE. HE HAD MADE SUGGESTIONS ON BOTH POINTS
AND HOPED THEY WOULD BE ACCEPTED. ON THE
BELGRADE-ZAGREB HIGHWAY SIGN DISPUTE, HE HAD
RECOMMENDED THAT BOTH CROATIAN AND RSK SIGNS BE
REPLACED BY INTERNATIONAL EUROPEAN SIGNS AND
DESIGNATIONS. HE SAID MIKELIC AND SARINIC REACTED
FAVORABLY TO THE IDEA.

6. MILOSEVIC SAID IT WAS IMPORTANT TO CONTINUE
PUSHING IMPLEMENTATION OF THE ECONOMIC AGREEMENT,
BUT ALSO TO EXERT "STRONG, PUBLIC PRESSURE" ON
TUDJMAN TO REVERSE THE UNPROFOR DECISION. HERE,
THE ROLES OF THE U.S. AND GERMANY WOULD BE KEY.

MILOSEVIC REGRETTED GERMAN CG REP STEINER'S REMARK THAT KOHL WAS LEAVING THIS TASK TO KINKEL AND DID NOT WANT TO GET INVOLVED HIMSELF. MILOSEVIC SAID PUBLIC PRESSURE WOULD "HELP" TUDJMAN COPE WITH HIS DOMESTIC OPPOSITION.

7. RETURNING TO OUR DEMARCHE, MILOSEVIC SAID THE ONE AREA ON WHICH HE WOULD COUNSEL CAUTION WAS TABLING OF THE Z-4 PLAN. BY RAISING THESE SENSITIVE ISSUES PREMATURELY, WE COULD FORCE BOTH SIDES TO POSTURE AND DAMAGE THE IMPROVED ATMOSPHERE FROM THE CONFIDENCE-BUILDING MEASURES. THERE WAS STRONG LOGIC TO THE PHASED APPROACH, MILOSEVIC RECALLED. IT WAS IMPORTANT NOT TO LINK THE PLAN TO THE ECONOMIC AGREEMENT AND TO GIVE THE LATTER A CHANCE TO TAKE ROOT. HE RECOMMENDED WAITING AT LEAST A "MONTH OR A MONTH AND A HALF" AND THEN RE-EVALUATING THE SITUATION.

8. I ASKED HOW HE THOUGHT THE KRAJINA SERBS WOULD REACT TO THE Z-4 PLAN. HE SAID HE THOUGHT THEY WOULD REJECT IT, BUT COULD NOT BE SURE. HE CLAIMED NOT TO HAVE DISCUSSED IT WITH THEM BECAUSE THE FINAL PROVISIONS WERE STILL UNCLEAR. MUCH WOULD DEPEND ON HOW WELL THE CONFIDENCE-BUILDING MEASURES WORKED. HE SAID THAT, IN ANY CASE, THOSE WOULD HAVE TO BE DIRECT TALKS BETWEEN KNIN AND ZAGREB TO WHICH HE DID NOT WISH TO BE A PARTY.

9. I SAID THAT I HAD NO DOUBT WE WOULD EXPECT HIM TO CONTINUE USING HIS INFLUENCE WITH THE KRAJINA SERBS IN SUCH NEGOTIATIONS. SHRUGGING HIS SHOULDERS, HE REPLIED THAT HE MIGHT TRY TO BE HELPFUL, AS ON THE ECONOMIC AGREEMENT, BUT WOULD NOT BECOME A "PARTY TO THE TALKS."

10. TURNING TO BOSNIA, I ASKED FOR HIS REACTION TO THE LATEST EFFORTS OF THE CONTACT GROUP, WHICH HAD NOT YET SUCCEEDED IN BRIDGING DIFFERENCES ON ACCEPTANCE OF THE CG PLAN. HE SAID THAT SOME TIME AGO HE HAD CHALLENGED BOSNIAN SERB "FOREIGN MINISTER" BUHA TO EXPLAIN THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN "STARTING POINT" AND "BASIS FOR" NEGOTIATIONS, AND BUHA COULD NOT DO IT. BUHA PROMISED TO WORK FOR MORE FLEXIBILITY IN THE BOSNIAN SERB POSITION BUT HE -- LIKE THE OTHERS -- "COULD NOT BE TRUSTED." THE PROBLEM WAS ALSO ON THE MUSLIM SIDE, WHERE IZETBEGOVIC AND GANIC WERE SCHEMING TO OUST SILAJDZIC. SUCH POWER STRUGGLES ALWAYS LED TO HARDENED POSITIONS.

11. I ASKED IF HE SAW SIMILAR POWER STRUGGLES ON THE BOSNIAN SERB SIDE. HE REPLIED THAT THERE THE KEY ISSUE WAS THE FUTURE OF SARAJEVO. KARADZIC AND KRAJISNIK WANTED TO HOLD ON TO AS MUCH OF THE CITY AS POSSIBLE, WHILE MOST OF THE DEPUTIES IN THE

BOSNIAN SERB ASSEMBLY WERE READY TO SWAP SARAJEVO FOR MUSLIM CONCESSIONS ELSEWHERE. ONCE THE NEGOTIATIONS STARTED, THIS DISPUTE COULD NOT BE PAPERED OVER, AND THE UNTENABLE KARADZIC POSITION WOULD BE REPUDIATED BY THE ASSEMBLY.

12. MILOSEVIC CONCLUDED BY SAYING THAT HE REMAINED OPTIMISTIC THAT TALKS WOULD BE INITIATED. NEITHER SIDE WOULD ALLOW THE OPPORTUNITY OF THE PRESENT CEASEFIRE TO BE LOST BECAUSE "99 PERCENT" OF BOTH BOSNIAN SERBS AND MUSLIMS WANTED THE WAR TO END.

13. COMMENT: ONCE AGAIN, MILOSEVIC APPEARED UPBEAT, CONFIDENT AND RELAXED, DESPITE REPORTS FROM BO PELLNAES (WHO HAD SEEN HIM ON FRIDAY) THAT HE HAD THEN LOOKED VERY TIRED. INTERESTINGLY, HE MADE NO REFERENCE TO UNSC 970, DESPITE CALLING IN THE BRITISH CHARGE AT MID-WEEK TO COMPLAIN ABOUT THE UK DRAFT AND -- ACCORDING TO THE LOCAL RUSSIANS -- BEING VERY UPSET BY THE FINAL TEXT. HIS MAIN MESSAGE WAS TO FOCUS ON WHAT WAS DOABLE IN THE NEXT FEW MONTHS -- IMPLEMENTATION OF THE ECONOMIC AGREEMENT -- AND NOT RISK GREATER POLARIZATION OF KNIN AND ZAGREB THROUGH TABLING OF THE Z-4 PLAN. THIS IS CLEARLY A SELF-SERVING APPROACH FROM THE SERB VIEWPOINT, BUT TACTICALLY NOT ONE WITHOUT MERIT IF IT APPEARS THAT THE PUBLIC REACTION TO THE Z-4 PLAN IS LIKELY TO BE NEGATIVE ON BOTH SIDES.

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SECT: SECTION: 01 OF 01

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Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

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